

The Uncanny Valley of Creepy Men

Understanding the Uncanny Valley

By making robots or artificial intelligence more human, our affinity for them keeps increasing. One of the initial chapters in the book, "I, Robot" by Isaac Asimov tells a story about how a little girl develops a deep emotional relationship with her house robot, *Robbie*. Robbie looked and moved like a human, sure it had a body of tin, but the girl had the deepest conversations of her pre-pubescent life with the robot as she would with any human companion, or maybe even deeper than that. The robot would converse with her in a humanistic manner, and would have emotionally fueled responses to any situation. It is debatable if the robot ever actually feels anything or is it only emoting. The girl develops a deep connection to Robbie (so much so that the girl falls into a depression on separation with Robbie).

Familiarity with human character is what leads to the development of this affinity towards something non-human. Mori (2012) talks of how prosthetic hands are obviously modelled off of real human hands, so the designers/engineers tend to add elements like veins, muscle and fingernails so that it looks more human-like. From what I understand, this is done (1) in order to make the user feel less disoriented by giving them the feel of "the real deal" and (2) to make the people around the user comfortable. How much of these objectives are achieved is questionable.

Think of how cartoons directed at children are depicted having human-like facial expressions with complex thoughts, feelings, desires and intentions. It could be argued that this helps the child develop empathy for animals. And this affinity keeps on growing as the similarity to human characteristics grows until it dips so bad that we fall down the uncanny valley. The writer Mori describes this to be antithetical to the standard monotonically increasing function y increasing with the variable x (depicted by the relation $y = f(x)$). The uncanny valley is a valley of an extreme eerie feeling, something that you can't comfortably put your finger on. This feeling could be entirely intuitive as well, not being triggered by anything perceptual.

The Creepy Man

How can we explain the phenomena of the uncanny valley to someone who has never experienced it? Things are scary, disgusting and gross; but few things are creepy in a way that is accompanied by a sense of vagueness to it. **Old, used dolls tend to morph into some pretty creepy creatures. But a good** parallel to the the uncanny valley feeling of human-robot interaction could be drawn characterised by an uneasy, eerie feeling that makes you nearly nauseous could be equated to the unique feeling of encountering a modern porn-brained perverted, creepy man (I will be using the acronym CM henceforth) in the wild. They will induce terror in you. Not just horror of a bad thing happening to you, but the terror of expecting something extremely dreadful to happen but you never know when it would happen, how it would happen, and would it *really* happen? I believe it is only women-presenting individuals who have had this feeling. I believe even when men are approached by such a man (with sexual or non-sexual intentions), the same feeling of eeriness could not be experienced. The reason for this will hopefully unfurl as I clarify my stance on this parallel.

I conjecture that one of the main reasons for this is the social dynamic between men and women in the present day. It is a dynamic of power. It is informed by centuries of violence and dominion of one sex over the other. Its foundation is on the constant historical pursuit of control and ownership, primarily through

the means of violence. The general physiological inferiority of strength only helps to fortify the nature of this relationship. So, be it evolutionary or acquired, the dangerous dynamic persists.

One of the major reasons that artificial intelligence systems are modelled off of human-like attributes in their behavior is to maintain the sense of familiarity which would minimize fear. A similar blueprint is adopted by a creepy man attempting to talk to a woman for purely sexual gains or for sexual intimidation. **I would like to clarify that I mean by sexual intimidation.** The fear that a woman experiences being in situations where she holds limited or no avail of escape from it, the situation being dominated by a het-cis man is sexual in nature. The fear is one of being sexually threatened, violated, defiled.

Uncertainty/Vagueness

Like AI systems that hope to perfectly emulate human attributes, the CM hopes to don the garb of an unassuming, regular guy who has nothing but regular intentions who talks and walks in a regular fashion. However, simply that will not result in an uncanny valley feeling.

It is popularly known through research that things or people are creepy due to the uncertainty or unpredictability of intentions. Creepy feelings arise due to something called *disrupted mentalizations*, which are not able to grasp the workings of the mind of the other (Kjeldgaard-Christiansen; Clasen, 2023). With creepy men directed at women, we are most certainly certain of their intentions. What is uncertain is what they plan to do in order to satisfy those intentions, and like I mentioned earlier, uncertainty about when it would happen or would it actually happen or is it only intimidation for the fun of it? The doubt of it happening is not a reason to argue, “Well, you shouldn’t be creeped out then. Just relax!” It is a feeling of terror that is unavoidable. A strange conversation may lead to sexual jokes, grabbing your hand, or maybe a very apparent brush against your chest. It might seem like I’m exaggerating but the reality is even more grim. A characteristic feature of any example of the uncanny valley is the glaring non-human attribute. The reason we have that eerie sensation with AI systems is when they attempt to be life-like and human-like but fail to do so. **Similarly, when CM is not perfect with his costume, and you catch a glimpse into that slight crack into his near-perfectly moulded mask is when an uncanny valley comes to the surface.** This crack could be several things, a slightly longer glance at your breasts, standing too close for human comfort, asking an extremely personal question being practically a stranger or acts of kindness that far exceed regular human niceties. As soon as it cracks, an eerie, dystopic feeling of fear emerges. This is fear of the unknown. Even after having many experiences with a number of CM, the fear of the unknown remains because not every CM’s acts are the same and hence cannot be accurately predicted. They are varied, from being utterly obnoxious to life-threatening.

Like a mask hides the true emotions of a person underneath, a mask is donned by CM to conceal their true intentions in a way that you cannot determine if they are a threat or not; to introduce vagueness to the situation. On the surface, that is their face, they have a nice, arguably pleasant smile. A smile – supposed to convey friendliness, absence of danger. But those are exactly the ways in which a smile can be used as a soft weapon, to get you to lower your guard. Encountering a CM does not incite a typical fear response, but a very thin line between fear and not-fear, the anticipation of fear. Something terrible might just happen, but it doesn’t.

What is special about situations involving CM is that you can definitively say that the uncanny valley feeling cannot be attributed to anything else contributing to the situation where you encounter the CM. Even if you meet this man in the light of day in a public place with several people around, the feeling still persists. This strengthens the belief that it is not correlation, it is causation.

Movement

According to Mori, movement is what amplifies the peaks and valleys of the graph. The affinity experienced is deeper and the eerie feeling is also more intense and fear inducing. He gives the example of the movement of a prosthetic hand, which induces the feeling of extreme creepiness that the subject experiences. I argue in CM, movement plays the exact same role.

The feeling of affinity that was developed at conversing with what seemed to be a regular human being without any ill-intentions quickly vanishes. The person in front of you is trying to be something they are not in order to minimize your fear. Flashing a charming smile and innocent reactions to lull you into a false sense of security. In terms of agency, the parallel I draw does not work that well because modelling AI systems on human-like reasoning and behavior is done by humans, for humans; to increase comprehensibility and the resulting behavior, and easeful integration of a new entity into human life. However, the CM does it to another person for exploitation¹. Like a predator would try to create a fearless environment for its prey.

Conclusion

Mori seems to think that human beings being equipped with this eerie sensation is in favor of us. It is an integral part of self preservation. It is a way for our instincts to protect us from proximal dangers. Cheesy sci-fi films will think of the grossest, technology-driven and scary monsters in the future that are hell-bent on destroying our lives. However, fortunately or unfortunately, for women, the gravest danger still remains the CM. Not someone who is highly motivated to knock down their entire lives, but only someone who has perverted pleasures and notions attached to intimidation and strives for that pleasure.

In emulating the image of a regular guy, they not only destroy their own humanity but fail to consider their object of intimidation a human too. They have gamified connection. The game being if you are able to trick this woman (not human) smartly enough, you might just get sex with lesser effort. And sex is even more pleasurable for CM if it is accompanied by fear in the other. **You might be able to grab it, steal it, possess it, display it as a trophy of your intellect and wit on your drawing room mantle.**

I would argue that the biggest loss that the CM faces is still the loss of his own humanity, something that did not require a song and a dance and a three-act performance to be felt. Something that was unavoidable when he was 8 years old and would help up a friend who had fallen down the stairs. **His humanity was inadvertently loud when he would let a butterfly perch on his fist, and he'd do nothing but look.** I do not wish to brand the most violent creatures of society today as incorrigible. I hope for a miracle everyday, more so for their sake than mine. The world has been worse off since they hit puberty, flowers

¹ On re-reading, I realise the parallel can be extended to include the intent of exploitation too, but I will not do that here.

droop lower since then, the sun is harsher since then, and the muddy roads in the monsoon are not cool and soft on your feet, they intend to swallow you and trap you down like quicksand.